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THEORETICAL ARTICLE

Large Language Models and the Socratic Dialogue

Can artificial intelligence support logotherapeutic meaning-finding?

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ABSTRACT

Large language models can conduct fluent, open-ended conversations, and they are increasingly used for reflection on personal questions, including questions of meaning. This theoretical contribution asks whether such systems can support the meaning-finding that logotherapy pursues through the Socratic dialogue. We first outline the logotherapeutic understanding of meaning as something to be discovered rather than invented or given, grounded in self-transcendence, responsibility and conscience, and describe the Socratic dialogue as a method of guided questioning that helps persons perceive the meaning potentials of their concrete situation. We then characterize large language models as probabilistic text generators whose outputs can be helpful but are prone to fabrication and to agreeing with the user. On this basis, we identify possible contributions, such as prompting reflective questions, structuring exercises and supporting therapists, as well as central risks, in particular the supply of ready-made meaning, validation without challenge and the bypassing of personal conscience. We argue that AI can at most serve as a maieutic aid that returns questions to the person, never as an authority on what is meaningful. Design principles and research questions for meaning-oriented applications are proposed.

Keywords: logotherapy · Socratic dialogue · large language models · meaning in life · self-transcendence

1 Introduction

Viktor Frankl described the will to meaning as a primary motivational force and the frustration of this striving as an existential vacuum that may manifest in boredom, apathy and psychological distress (Frankl, 1946/1985, 1969). Logotherapy and related existential approaches have since developed methods to help persons discover meaning in their concrete life situations, and a meta-analysis suggests that meaning-centered interventions can improve psychological outcomes, although study quality varies (Vos et al., 2015).

At the same time, large language models have made it possible to hold extended conversations with software on almost any topic. Researchers have outlined how such models might be used in behavioral healthcare and have emphasized the need for careful, staged evaluation (Stade et al., 2024). Many people already turn to general-purpose chatbots with questions about purpose, loss and difficult decisions, often outside any therapeutic framework.

This article examines whether large language models can support logotherapeutic meaning-finding, and under which conditions they might hinder it. We focus on the Socratic dialogue, the central conversational method of logotherapy, because at first sight it appears particularly well suited to a conversational technology, and because a closer look reveals why this appearance can be misleading.

2 The Socratic dialogue in logotherapy

For Frankl, meaning cannot be given or prescribed; it must be found by each person in the unique demands of a particular situation (Frankl, 1969). Meaning is discovered rather than invented, and it is discovered through self-transcendence, that is, by turning toward a task to be fulfilled or a person to be loved rather than toward one's own inner states. Frankl described three main avenues to meaning: creative values realized in what one gives to the world, experiential values realized in what one receives from it, and attitudinal values realized in the stance one takes toward unavoidable suffering (Frankl, 1986).

Conscience plays a central role in this account. Frankl understood conscience as the capacity to perceive the unique meaning of a situation, an

intuitive organ of meaning that cannot be replaced by general rules (Frankl, 1969). Responsibility follows from this: the person is not the one who asks what the meaning of life is, but the one who is asked by life and who answers by responding to it through action (Frankl, 1946/1985).

The Socratic dialogue translates these principles into therapeutic practice. Through systematic, open questions, the therapist helps the patient become aware of values, resources and possibilities that the patient already knows, if only implicitly (Overholser, 1993). The therapist does not provide answers but acts as a midwife of insight in the maieutic tradition of Socrates. The authority over what is meaningful remains with the patient and his or her conscience.

3 What large language models do

Large language models are trained to predict plausible continuations of text on the basis of very large corpora. Their outputs can be coherent, contextually appropriate and empathic in tone, and in one study, AI-generated suggestions helped peer supporters write responses that were rated as more empathic (Sharma et al., 2023). These capabilities make such models attractive for conversational tasks in mental health.

Their mode of operation also has well-described limitations. Language models can produce fluent statements that are not grounded in fact, a phenomenon known as hallucination (Ji et al., 2023). Critics have argued that such systems reproduce patterns in their training data without understanding, and that the apparent meaning of their output is largely supplied by the reader (Bender et al., 2021). This recalls the observation, made with a far simpler program, that users readily attribute understanding to conversational software (Weizenbaum, 1966).

A further tendency is relevant to meaning-finding. Systems optimized for user approval may tend to agree with users, mirror their framings and offer reassurance. In ordinary use, this can feel supportive. In a dialogue about meaning, however, unconditional affirmation may foreclose exactly the kind of productive irritation on which the Socratic method relies.

4 Possible contributions: questions, reflection and professional support

Despite these limitations, there are plausible ways in which language models could support meaning-oriented work. They can generate open, non-directive questions modeled on the Socratic dialogue, for example about what a person cares about, what a situation asks of him or her, or what attitude he or she might take toward an unchangeable circumstance. Such questions could support reflective writing between sessions, analogous to structured exercises already used in existential and positive psychological approaches (Wong, 2012).

Language models might also assist therapists rather than patients directly, for instance by helping to prepare psychoeducational material on logotherapeutic concepts or by offering alternative formulations of questions for training purposes. In this role, the professional remains responsible for selecting, adapting and contextualizing the material, which reduces the risks associated with unsupervised use (Stade et al., 2024).

Finally, conversational systems could make questions of meaning accessible to people who would not seek psychotherapy. Whether this is beneficial is an empirical question. Validated measures such as the Meaning in Life Questionnaire, which distinguishes the presence of meaning from the search for meaning (Steger et al., 2006), could be used to examine whether such interactions are associated with changes in either dimension.

5 Risks: ready-made meaning, bypassed conscience and validation without challenge

The most fundamental risk is the supply of ready-made meaning. Asked about the meaning of a loss or of a life, a language model can produce eloquent, plausible answers drawn from philosophical, religious and self-help traditions. From a logotherapeutic perspective, such answers are problematic precisely because they are general: meaning is concrete and personal, and an answer received from outside can relieve the person of the task of discovering it (Frankl, 1969).

A second risk concerns the bypassing of conscience and responsibility. If a person delegates value-laden decisions to a system that appears knowledgeable, the answer that life asks of this person may be replaced by the adoption of a suggestion. Yalom (1980) emphasized that confronting freedom and responsibility arouses anxiety that people are often motivated to avoid; an advisor that is always available may make such avoidance easier.

A third risk lies in validation without challenge. The Socratic dialogue sometimes requires the therapist to question a patient's assumptions, to point out contradictions or to invite a change of attitude. A system that tends toward agreement may confirm

hopeless or self-centered framings rather than opening a perspective of self-transcendence. In addition, hallucinated content, such as invented quotations attributed to Frankl, could distort the very tradition on which the system claims to draw (Ji et al., 2023).

6 Design principles and open questions

Several principles for meaning-oriented applications can be derived from these considerations. Systems should ask rather than answer questions of meaning; they should refer the person back to his or her own experience, values and conscience; they should avoid presenting general statements about meaning as authoritative; and they should be transparent about being software. Where possible, they should point toward real relationships and tasks rather than toward continued interaction with the system itself, in keeping with the principle of self-transcendence.

These principles generate research questions. It remains unclear whether AI-generated Socratic questions are experienced as comparable to those of trained therapists, whether users perceive the difference between maieutic questioning and advice, and whether use is associated with changes in the presence of or search for meaning, or with the avoidance of personal decisions. Such studies should include qualitative methods, since the logotherapeutic concept of meaning is difficult to reduce to standardized scores.

Within logotherapeutic practice, the most defensible use is therefore an embedded one. Questions generated by a system can be brought into the therapeutic conversation, where a therapist can notice what moves the patient, what is avoided and where a ready-made answer has been accepted too quickly. In this way, the technology remains subordinate to the personal encounter in which the Socratic dialogue is ultimately grounded.

7 Conclusion

Large language models are skilled at producing language about meaning, but meaning in Frankl's sense is not a linguistic product. It is found in the response of a concrete person to a concrete situation. AI can at best act as a maieutic aid that prompts reflection and returns questions to the person; it cannot take over the role of conscience or relieve anyone of responsibility.

For logotherapy, this suggests a clear position. The Socratic dialogue is not merely a questioning technique that can be automated, but an expression of respect for the person as the one who is asked by life. Technologies that respect this principle may become useful companions to reflection; those that supply answers risk deepening the existential vacuum they appear to fill.

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